

Dust Didn't Blind Visitor To Beauty and Business Air

By HARRY GILSTRAP
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One day in 1927 the young man from Alabama looked out the window of his room in the Blackstone Hotel in Amarillo and was somewhat startled to see a sky which he now describes as having been of "a beautiful beige color."

His surprise was understandable. The sky's unwanted hue was the result of an Amarillo dust storm, the first Benjamin Rochmill Solnick ever had seen.

IN THE 33 years since, he has seen a great many dust storms, including some which were worse than that first one. He also has seen a depression and assorted recessions.

But he has experienced success in business, too, and satisfaction as a tireless civic worker for the welfare of his adopted home town, and perhaps it is characteristic of Ben Solnick, president of The Hollywood at 715 Polk, that he still can recall the color of that unpleasant sky of 1927 as "a beautiful beige."

Ben Solnick is an amiable, pipe-smoking, 55-year-old man who talks easily, with humor and, when pressed by an interviewer, with pleasure in reminiscence.

He would rather talk about his college days, for instance, than about the civic honors he has earned and won. A thorough Texan now, he maintains obvious pride in his alma mater, the University of Alabama, from which he had been graduated less than a year before that 1927 dust storm.

Ben Solnick was born in Selma, Ala., on May 2, 1905, and raised in Marion, a little town of 2,000, just 20 miles from Selma, where his immigrant father operated Sam Solnick Dry Goods. Sam Solnick died in 1931, still in Marion. Mrs. Sam Solnick, who also came over from the old country, lives in Plainview now.

Their eldest son properly is proud of them.

"They educated four children," he says. "They didn't have much after that."

BEN WAS graduated from home-town Marion Institute, a junior college, in 1924. He had won five letters in athletics (football, basketball, baseball) in two years. He also had been a member of the tennis squad, which didn't award letters.

His coach was a man named Wilkie, whose brother was to be an unsuccessful but dynamic Republican candidate for president in 1940. Ben recalls that his parents decided one time that it wasn't advisable for him to go to Tuscaloosa with the Marion Institute football team to play the Alabama freshmen.

He had to go to Coach Wilkie's home to break the news and found the coach in the bathtub, where Wilkie sat while he heard young Solnick's tearful explanation.

"The 'Bama freshmen beat us a hundred-and-something to nothing," he also remembers. "I guess it wouldn't have made much difference if I HAD made the trip."

He learned to play the clarinet while at Marion Institute, too, in a 20-by-60 site next door to the and at the university he won a first prize in solo clarinet. On his office wall now hangs a framed photo of "Bama's M.L." (his manager. Soon he changed lion-dollar Band." 32 men in the name to The Hollywood, including the director and young Ben Solnick) uniformed in straw



BEN SOLNICK

—Globe-Times Staff Photo

hats, white shirts and trousers, red sashes and ties.

Doesn't look like much compared with the college bands of today, Solnick admits. And the band didn't even get to go to Pasadena for the Rose Bowl game of 1926, one of the greatest of 'em all, in which 'Bama beat Washington, 20-19.

"They hired a band out there to represent us," Solnick says.

TWO OF THE greatest stars of that great 'Bama team, Pooley Goods. Sam Solnick died in 1931, still in Marion. Mrs. Sam Solnick, who also came over from the old country, lives in Plainview now.

Solnick himself went out for baseball, his favorite sport, at Alabama, but quit when he lost his favorite glove, reasoning that he only had a year of eligibility anyway.

He was a member of Zeta Beta Tau social fraternity, and perhaps he thought baseball might interfere with his social life, too.

He was graduated with a degree in commerce and business administration, and started using it right away. He had helped his father in the family store and, while in junior college, had gone to El Dorado, Ariz., to gain ready-to-wear experience in his uncle's store there.

Now he rejoined the uncle, Robert Rochmill, and in 1927 Uncle Robert and others established two stores in Amarillo. Romine's, a men's wear store it folded, and Manheimer's, a women's wear store, and saw the beautiful beige sky.

MANHEIMER'S was on E. 6th, while at Marion Institute, too, in a 20-by-60 site next door to the and at the university he won a first prize in solo clarinet. On his office wall now hangs a framed photo of "Bama's M.L." (his manager. Soon he changed lion-dollar Band." 32 men in the name to The Hollywood, including the director and young Ben Solnick) uniformed in straw

opened meanwhile in Plainview and Abilene. During World War II, after Ben's two brothers, Harry and Clarence, entered the Army Air Corps and the Army, respectively, the Abilene store was moved to Amarillo.

It was called the Fifth Avenue Shop and it and the Plainview store were operated by Ben's sister, Mrs. Dan Miller of Plainview, and his wife's sister. The Fifth Avenue Shop no longer exists.

There now are Bentley stores in Pampa, Borger, Plainview, Lubbock and Elida, Okla., all owned by the family but run as independent operations. Active in the operation are Robert Rochmill, Ben Solnick, Clarence Solnick and Mrs. Miller. Harry Solnick died in an automobile crash last year. The family unveiled a stone to his honor recently.

BEN SOLNICK'S interest and activity in civic affairs began after his marriage in 1933. His father had been a Mason, and Ben became a member of Masonic Lodge No. 1239 here, of 32nd Degree Scottish Rite bodies, and of Khiva Temple of the Shrine.

He worked for the Red Cross for 7½ years during the war, serving as vice chairman, and with Mrs. Solnick in USO work. His other activities then and since have been legion: a partial list, roughly chronological:

President of B'nai B'rith; co-chairman of the United Jewish Appeals drive; treasurer of the Amarillo Philharmonic Assn. (in 1948, when A. Clyde Roller came here); member of the Market Week committee of the chamber of commerce; director of the YMCA; chairman of the downtown retail merchant committee of the chamber of commerce.

President of Temple B'nai Israel; chairman of the entertainment committee of the Downtown Kiwanis Club; member of the building committee of Temple B'nai Israel; chairman of the National Firms drive for the chamber of commerce; director of the Boy Scouts; chairman of the Amarillo Downtown Trade Board.

Member of the over-all committee of the USO and of the board of directors of the Community Council; vice chairman of the Red Cross; director of the Area Council of the Boy Scouts; member of the Community Chest budget committee; director of the Amarillo Credit Assn.; chairman of the budget committee and director of the Downtown Kiwanis Club; trustee of Temple B'nai Israel.

President of the Amarillo Community Chest (now the United Fund); member of the executive board of the Potter-Randall Citizens Committee; president of Downtown Park & Shop of Amarillo; vice president of the Amarillo Credit Assn.; director of Family Service and Travelers Aid; director of the Area Foundation and of the Better Business Bureau; West Texas Stadium Drive.

And a few weeks ago he retired as president of the Better Business Bureau.

"I ENJOY doing civic work," he says. "You're beholden to the city in which you live. You can't let others do everything. You've got to help your own city in its

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